

BREAKING POINT

Indian football stands at a crossroads after yet another humiliating defeat, exposing deep-rooted failures in coaching, talent development, and governance. Can the Blue Tigers **rebuild** before their legacy fades completely?



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When the full-time whistle blew at the Kai Tak Stadium in Hong Kong, China, the Indian football team stood frozen — hapless and defeated.

A team that India had hammered for four goals without reply in their previous clash just beat the Blue Tigers 1-0 — another loss for India to a lower-ranked opponent (26 spots) and the first loss to Hong Kong in a competitive fixture since 1993.

The men's football team and the state of Indian football remain in tatters. India can no longer afford to put a foot wrong in its next four matches if it wants to qualify for the 2027 Asian Cup.

But where did it all go wrong for the national team? The lion's share of blame has typically fallen on head

coach Manolo Marquez.

"When you are playing a new opponent — how they could play, whether they will attack or defend — these are things a coach should explain to his players well," Subrata Bhattacharya, former India defender, tells *Sportstar*. "I think that communication and general coordination among players were missing. As a result, every player played their individual game."

Marquez, who won the Indian Super League (ISL) — India's top flight — title with Hyderabad FC, took charge after Igor Stimac was shown the door in June last year, following a poor showing at the 2023 Asian Cup and an early exit from the World Cup qualifiers. But in the year since he took charge, India won just one match in eight — an international friendly against the Maldives.

"If you look at it, the entire team — on and off the ground — has been in a mess," Bhaichung Bhutia, former

India striker and captain, says. "I think it is time for Kalyan Chaubey (president of the All India Football Federation [AIFF]) to step down. He bypassed the entire technical committee (to select the coach)."

"Then there have been three general secretaries (Shaji Prabhakaran, Anilkumar Prabhakaran and M. Satyanarayan) in two-and-a-half years under Chaubey. I think things are quite bad when you offer USD 50,000 for a win."

Not enough international games

Cash incentives have hardly led to encouraging results for the national team. In 2006, the men's team was promised one lakh rupees should it beat Japan, ranked 100 spots above it, and INR 50,000 for a draw.

Hong Kong, meanwhile, is a side ranked 26 spots below India. India lost on both occasions: 0-6 to Japan and 0-1 to Hong Kong. Could that money be invested to arrange more